

Dominik Livaković is the preferred choice in goal. In front of him, he will have a solid balance of experience in Domagoj Vida and youth in Joško Gvardiol. Josip Stanišić and Josip Juranović should be the preferred fullbacks.

Veteran Ivan Perišić will, as usual, pose a threat in the forward line and will be expected to support the likes of Andrej Kramarić and Bruno Petković, while Kramarić has the best statistics among the available forwards.

With Croatia's best finishes in this tournament being quarterfinal appearances in 1996 and 2008, head coach Dalić knows that Euro 2024 is the last chance to win a trophy with the remaining members of this generation.

The next chapter for La Roja

After Spain's 'Golden Generation', it can write a new chapter with the enviable talent in its ranks. Winner of the Nations League under new manager Luis de la Fuente, Spain has a refreshed look, making it a title contender.

Unai Simon should be the preferred choice between the sticks. In front of him, centre-back Aymeric Laporte will partner with Robin Le Normand. Alejandro Grimaldo as left fullback is almost a certainty after winning the title with Bayer Leverkusen.

In midfield, Spain has Rodri — arguably the best defensive midfielder in world football. Pedri's vision to unlock defences should be crucial for Spain, but his fitness will be a crucial factor. His Barcelona teammate Gavi, who will miss out due to injury, is a big loss for La Roja.

Lamine Yamal has grabbed headlines as the 'next big thing' and should be one of the first names in the Spain attack. However, at 16, Yamal will need to be managed by De La Fuente carefully to prevent injuries or fatigue. Alvaro Morata looks likely to play the No. 9 role.

For the wingers, Dani Olmo, Nico Williams, and Ferran Torres are likely contenders. The coach needs to select his wingers carefully, as his preferred 4-3-3 formation will depend heavily on how the wingers service the centre-forward.

The odd one out

Albania finds itself out of place in a group of heavyweights, and coach Sylvinho will need a miraculous effort to achieve a positive result from the group.

Despite having experienced players like Ivan Balliu and Elseid Hysaj in defence, Nedim Bajrami in midfield, and Armando Broja in attack, Albania's squad is vastly inferior on paper compared to Italy, Spain, and Croatia.

However, having secured a top-two position in its qualifying group to advance directly, it will take inspiration from all the underdogs who have beaten stronger teams before.

Knockouts prediction:

With three strong teams, it will be daring to assume which teams would qualify. However, Italy and Spain look likely to advance from Group B.

Croatia is also a strong contender, but an ageing squad might prevent it from replicating its consistent performance on the international stage.

PLAYERS TO WATCH OUT FOR



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RODRI

Replacing a player like Sergio Busquets is no easy feat. His composure and skill on the ball gave Spain stability in midfield. But in Rodri, La Roja finally has an able central defender who can pull the strings from midfield. Despite having a different profile than Busquets, Rodri's presence in midfield and his balance between his astute defensive and attacking capabilities make him a player to watch out for in the Euros.



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GIANLUCA SCAMACCA

Despite having poor statistics in national colours, it cannot be negated that Scamacca had an excellent season with Atalanta (19 goals and eight assists), winning the Europa League. With Italy lacking a proven No. 9, Scamacca will be eager to step up in his country's title defence.